SOP: Minimum Pay Rise and Pay Gaps Review

Hakim Group Payroll | Version 1.0 | October 2026 | Owner: Head of Payroll

1. Purpose

This SOP explains how to work out the cost of a rise in the legal minimum hourly pay (National Minimum Wage and National Living Wage), and how it affects pay gaps for Managers and DOs. It uses the workbook HG_Minimum_Pay_and_Pay_Gaps_Template.xlsx. You can run it without Claude.

2. When to run it

- **Forecast:** after the Budget or the government announcement of new rates (usually October or November). Use the latest payroll report.
- **Final figures:** in March, before the April payroll. Use the March payroll report so the figures match the people we employ at that time.
- **Ad hoc:** if rates change, or if management ask for a new scenario (for example a different pay gap floor).

3. What you need

- **Workbook:** a fresh copy of HG_Minimum_Pay_and_Pay_Gaps_Template.xlsx.
- **Rates:** the official rates from GOV.UK (the Budget document or the GOV.UK minimum wage rates page). Do not rely on news websites.
- **Payroll report:** one row per job, with the 14 fields below.

Column	Field	Notes
A	Payroll Ref	One row per job. People with two jobs appear twice.
B	Category	For example Practice Support, Practice Clinical.
C	Job type	Exact text, for example Optical Assistant, Practice Manager, Apprentice.
D	Basis	For example Permanent - Part Time. For information only.
E	Work location	Practice code. For information only.
F	Pay basis	Annual or Hourly. Must be spelt exactly like this.
G	Occupancy start date	Used to see if an apprentice is in their first year.
H	FTE	Full-time equivalent, for example 0.52667.
I	FTE salary	Full-time yearly salary. For hourly paid staff this is the hourly rate.
J	Pro-rated salary	Yearly pay for the hours they work.
K	Contract hours	Weekly contracted hours. Used for hourly paid staff.
L	Weeks worked	Usually 52. Used for hourly paid staff.
M	Hourly rate	Current hourly rate.
N	Date of birth	A real date (dd/mm/yyyy). Column O works out the age on the date the new rates start. Before sharing the file, including with Claude, copy column O and Paste Special, Values over column N, so only ages remain.

4. Step by step

1. **Save a new copy:** open the template and save it as HG_Minimum_Pay_Review_[Month Year].xlsx in the secure payroll folder. Never work in the master template.

2. **Update the Rates sheet:** type the new rates and start date into the blue cells (B2 to B7). Check the company NI rate and threshold (B8, B9) and the pension rate and limits (B10 to B13). Update today's rates (B16 to B19) if they have changed since the last run.
3. **Check the pay gap groups:** on the Rates sheet, columns E to G list which job types count as Managers, DOs and Optical Assistants, and which roles are protected (Y). Add any new job titles.
4. **Prepare the payroll report:** put the 14 fields in the order shown in section 3. Delete any extra columns, for example a row-number column. A column in the wrong place is the most common cause of wrong answers.
5. **Paste the data:** on the Data sheet, click cell A2, then use Paste Special, then Values. Only paste into the blue columns A to N. The yellow columns work out by themselves and are locked.
6. **Run the checks:** complete the checks in section 5 before you read any totals.
7. **Read the results:** the Summary sheet shows the cost. The Pay Gaps sheet shows the effect on Managers and DOs and the cost of three options.
8. **Prepare the management reports:** see section 7.
9. Remove dates of birth before sharing: copy column O, then Paste Special, Values over column N. Only ages remain and all figures stay the same.
10. **Approve and store:** password-protect the workbook before you send it (File, then Info, then Protect Workbook). Store it in the secure payroll folder. It holds personal data.

5. Quality checks

Check	Where	What good looks like
Row count	Summary B4	Matches the number of jobs in the payroll report.
Ages	Summary B11	0 jobs with a missing age. Filter Data column R for 'Age missing'.
Odd ages	Data column O	No ages under 16 unless confirmed (with work permits), none over 80 unless confirmed.
Pay basis	Data column F	Only the words Annual or Hourly.
Categories	Summary A35	Says 'Categories reconcile to the total'. If not, add the missing category name in Summary column A.
Below minimum now	Summary B13	Investigate and correct each one before the next pay run.
Spot check	Data sheet	Check 3 rows by hand using the worked example in section 6.
Formula errors	All sheets	No #VALUE!, #N/A or #DIV/0! in yellow columns.

6. Worked example (one row, checked by hand)

A salaried Optical Assistant aged 58, paid £12.71 an hour, with a pro-rated salary of £13,053.17. The new rate for 21 and over is £13.21.

Step	Calculation	Result
New yearly pay	£13,053.17 x £13.21 / £12.71	£13,566.67
Salary increase	£13,566.67 - £13,053.17	£513.50
Company NI	15% x £513.50 (both above the £5,000 threshold)	£77.02
Company pension	3% x £513.50 (both between £6,240 and £50,270)	£15.40
Total extra cost a year	£513.50 + £77.02 + £15.40	£605.92

Hourly paid example: aged 19, paid £10.50 an hour, 10 hours a week for 52 weeks. New rate £11.27. Salary increase = (£11.27 - £10.50) x 10 × 52 = £400.40.

7. Preparing the management reports

Option A, with Claude: type "national minimum wage" in Claude and attach the populated workbook or the payroll report, after you have replaced the dates of birth with ages (step 9). The National Minimum Wage Review skill (saved in Notion under Hakim Group Payroll) checks the rates on GOV.UK, checks the data, and writes both one-pagers and the cover email.

Option B, without Claude: open last year's one-pagers in Word and update each figure from the workbook using this map.

Figure on the one-pager	Where to find it
Jobs needing a rise	Summary B5 (and the age split in B6 to B9)
Today / From April / Extra cost table	Summary H6 to K9 (pay, NI, pension, total)
Yearly and monthly cost	Summary B19 and B20
Whole company staff costs and % change	Summary I17, J17 and L17
Teams split	Summary rows 25 to 34
Staff with no set hours	Summary B10
Staff turning 18 or 21	Summary B14
Managers and DOs gaps	Pay Gaps rows 5 to 7 and 10 to 11
Gap bands	Pay Gaps rows 15 to 19
Option costs and people	Pay Gaps rows 23 to 25

8. Troubleshooting

What you see	Likely cause	Fix
Age shows 127	The date of birth is not in column N, so the age is worked out from another column	Move the dates of birth into column N
Age is blank	Date of birth missing or stored as text	Re-type the date as dd/mm/yyyy
Nobody needs a rise	Rates sheet not updated, or columns shifted	Check Rates B4 to B7 and the column order
Hourly paid staff show £0 cost	No contract hours (zero hours)	Expected. They are flagged and listed as not costed
A formula has been overwritten	Pasted into a yellow column	Start again from a fresh copy of the template
Cannot paste or sort	The Data sheet is protected	Review, then Unprotect Sheet (no password)

9. Plain English glossary

- **Minimum rate:** the lowest hourly pay the law allows for each age group (National Minimum Wage and National Living Wage).
- **Pay gap:** how much more someone earns an hour than the minimum.
- **Pay compression:** when the minimum rises and people just above it do not get a rise, so the gap between levels gets smaller.
- **Qualifying earnings:** the slice of pay between the two pension limits that the company pension is worked out on.
- **Median:** the middle person when everyone is lined up by pay.

Version control

Version	Date	Change	By
1.0	28/10/2026	First version, based on the April 2027 review	Head of Payroll